St. Joseph's Anglo-Chinese School
F.5 English Language
Grammar – Lesson 4: Cleft sentences

Cleft sentences

Part 1: Proofreading quiz

Your teacher has put two paragraphs on the board. One argues that technology has made people lazier (Paragraph A). The other argues that technology has not made us lazier (Paragraph B). Each paragraph contains FIVE errors. The errors include relative clauses, inverted patterns and nominalisation. Proofread the paragraphs.

Everyone claims that technology makes life easier, but the truth is far less pleasant. Not only teenagers order food instead of cooking, but they also replace real conversations with emoji-filled messages. They sit for hours on apps, that were designed to save time, and end up achieving nothing meaningful. The convenient of instant delivery has destroyed any reason to walk to the shops. Rarely parents notice that their children have forgotten how to hold a proper conversation. Only when someone removes every screen from the house the family remembers what silence feels like.

Has technology really destroyed our generation, or have older adults simply misunderstood how we work? What they refuse to accept is that young people today manage schoolwork alongside online projects they could never have completed without the internet. Not only teenagers of the past lacked these tools, but they also missed the opportunities that digital platforms create. The believe that real work must involve physical sweat ignores the fact that running a website demands just as much effort. Rarely critics acknowledge that a teenager editing videos is working just as hard as someone lifting boxes. The reason because teenagers seem distracted is not laziness but the creative work they are doing on their phones. Only when adults look at the results of their work they can understand what teenagers actually achieve.

Part 2: Cleft sentences in formal writing

A cleft sentence breaks one idea into two parts so the most important information stands out. Study the patterns below.

Example 1: Wh-cleft – presenting a recommendation

Plain:	Schools should teach students how to communicate face to face.
More formal:	What schools should do is teach students how to communicate face to face.

Many teachers complain that their students cannot hold a proper conversation. What schools should do is teach students how to communicate face to face. A single workshop on active listening would help teenagers rebuild the skills that messaging apps have quietly taken away.

Class question 1 (Easy): Wh-cleft – recommendation

Simple sentence:	Schools should teach students how to start a real conversation.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'What schools should do …'.*

Class question 2 (Harder): Wh-cleft – recommendation

Simple sentence:	Teenagers need a safe space to practise speaking in groups.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'What teenagers need …'.*

Example 2: All-cleft – naming the only thing needed

Plain:	Teenagers only need one real conversation to remember the value of talking.
More formal:	All teenagers need is one real conversation to remember the value of talking.

Parents often buy expensive devices or hire tutors to help their children socially. All teenagers need is one real conversation to remember the value of talking. Once they experience the warmth of genuine human connection, the cold comfort of emojis will seem far less appealing.

Class question 1 (Easy): All-cleft

Simple sentence:	Teenagers only need one supportive friend to feel understood.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'All teenagers need …'.*

Class question 2 (Harder): All-cleft

Simple sentence:	Teenagers only need to feel brave for a moment to speak to a stranger.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'All teenagers need …'.*

Example 3: It-cleft – focusing on the cause

Plain:	People communicate less because they use messaging apps.
More formal:	It is messaging apps that make people communicate less.

Young people used to meet at the park after school, but now everyone sends messages from their bedrooms. A quick text is easier than a real conversation, so face-to-face friendships have become rare. It

is messaging apps that make people communicate less, and this change will only grow deeper as technology advances.

Class question 1 (Easy): It-cleft – the cause

Simple sentence:	Young people forget social skills because they text too much.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'It is the overuse of texting …'.*

Class question 2 (Harder): It-cleft – the cause

Simple sentence:	Teenagers struggle to focus because notifications interrupt them constantly.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'It is the constant interruptions …'.*

Example 4: It-cleft – setting up a contrast

Plain:	Some people blame social media, but smartphones cause the real problem.
More formal:	While some people blame social media, it is smartphones that cause the real problem.

Every day there are news stories about the dangers of social media. While some people blame social media, it is smartphones that cause the real problem. Without a phone in their pocket, teenagers could not check their accounts every five minutes.

Class question 1 (Easy): It-cleft – the contrast

Simple sentence:	Some blame phones for tiredness, but late-night gaming is the real cause.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'While some blame phones for tiredness …'.*

Class question 2 (Harder): It-cleft – the contrast

Simple sentence:	People say teenagers are antisocial, but they themselves avoid family dinners.
Prompt:	*Begin with 'While people say teenagers are antisocial …'.*

Part 3: Practice sets

Rewrite each sentence as a cleft sentence. The type of cleft to use is shown in brackets.

Set 1: It-cleft – the cause

Simple sentence:	Teenagers send short messages because they are afraid of real conversations.
Prompt:	*Use an IT-cleft.*

Set 2: Wh-cleft – the recommendation

Simple sentence:	Students need to practise face-to-face communication.
Prompt:	*Use a WHAT-cleft.*

Set 3: All-cleft – the only thing needed

Simple sentence:	Teenagers only need to be confident to start a real conversation.
Prompt:	*Use an ALL-cleft.*

Set 4: It-cleft – the contrast

Simple sentence:	People think technology is convenient, but it actually destroys our patience.
Prompt:	*Use an IT-cleft with WHILE.*

Part 4: Writing Task

Instructions:

1. Write ONE paragraph (about 80 words) explaining the influence of artificial intelligence on students, and suggesting ONE thing schools could do to help.

→ Use **ONE cleft sentence** (It is … that … / What … is … / All … needs to do is …).

→ Use a relative clause or an inverted pattern e.g. Not only … / Never … / Rarely …